LING 251: Stress and structure

Fall 2026
Thursday 2:00 – 4:50, Campbell 2122A

Instructors:

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Course materials website: http://jonahkatz.bol.ucla.edu/Stress/

Course description
This course explores how stress interacts with linguistic structure. We'll discuss the types of structure thought to be involved in stress (moras, syllables, feet, prosodic words), the phonetic and phonological expressions of those structures *beyond* stress, and attempts to probe such structures using a variety of behavioral and neural methods. A big part of the class will be brainstorming novel ways to test for the presence and nature of various structural features.

Organization
2:50 is a **long** time to sit in a room and talk about linguistics. We're going to try to bring in some variety and break things up each week by having an instructor presentation/review, a student presentation, and some free-form discussion/brainstorming. The general idea is to have about 50 minutes of each, although we don't expect that to be the same every week.

Grading:
25% participation and attendance
25% paper presentations
50% final paper (4 credits only)

Attendance and participation
Please don't miss class (obviously, there may be exceptions for professional travel, medical reasons, etc.). Please let us know if you're going to miss class and why. And please come prepared to discuss at least one of the main readings every week. We understand that there likely won't be time for every student to read every word of every paper: we get it. As a starting point, we recommend that you do a fairly close reading of at least one of the main papers each week (we'll sometimes recommend a particular one) and at least skim the rest of the papers. It will be useful to make notes about which aspects of a paper you did or did not like, understand, agree with, etc. We will have a mix of instructors and students presenting and summarizing papers in class, but this will be **very boring** if you don't come prepared to discuss.

* I'm also teaching an undergrad class this quarter and these office hours will be shared with that class. So you are welcome to come by, but there may be lots of students there. You can always make an appointment by emailing me.

Paper presentations
You will be responsible for presenting 1-2 papers over the course of the quarter. This doesn't mean that you need a long, detailed handout, slides, etc., although if you prefer to present things this way it's fine. For our part, we are going to try to be a bit less handout-centric than we normally are this quarter. One possible thing this could mean is having notes about the bits of the paper that are crucially important, and going through this information on the board, using examples from the paper or elsewhere.

Final paper
Propose a study (or carry one out!) to elucidate the nature of stress or structures that govern stress in one or more languages of your choosing. We intend this broadly: the study could involve reviewing or creating linguistic descriptions of stress/prosodic systems, production, perception, processing, musical behavior, motor behavior, or really any method you think would be useful for learning something new. We expect the papers to be in the 10-20 page range, with a (concise) literature review, a methods and materials section, and a section on possible patterns of results and what they would mean for your hypotheses. We've programmed in a paper proposal assignment in week 3 to encourage all of us to start thinking about the project earlier in the quarter.

Provisional schedule

Week	Date	Topic	Reading
0	Sept 24	Stress and footing (mostly in English): early Generative approaches	**Selkirk 1980**, McCarthy 1982, Hayes 1982
1	Oct 1	Foot structure and recursion	**Martínez-Paricio & Kager 2021, Golston 2021**, Bennett 2013, Lunden 2017, Jonah's data on phonetics of 'trapped lights' in English
2	Oct 8	Musical rhythm and Dynamic Attending	Jones & Boltz 1989, Repp 2010, Rothermich *et al.* 2012, Beier & Ferreira 2018, Bauer *et al.* failure to replicate 2015, something by Ahren Fitzroy
3	Oct 15	Probing stress and feet through other means, pt. 1 (grab bag)	Domahs *et al.* 2008, Franich 2021, Harris & Hyman 2022, Zuraw & Roca 2025, Franich 2025
Paper proposal due in class Oct 15			
4	Oct 22	Probing stress and feet through other means, pt. 2 (mostly word-segmentation and AGL)	Jusczyk & Houston 1999, Johnson & Jusczyk 2001, Bennett 2015, White *et al.* 2020
5	Oct 29	Stress representations and 'exponents'	Bosker 2022, Bujok *et al.* 2025a, b; TBA paper(s) on phonetics of stress in non-nuclear parts of syllables
6	Nov 5	Stress priming	Protopapas *et al.* 2016, Moore-Cantwell *et al.* 2024, Moore-Cantwell 2026
7	Nov 12	Stress exceptions vs. regularities	Andrikopoulou *et al.* 2021, García & Guzzo 2022, Bros *et al.* 2022
8	Nov 19	Stress in the lexicon	Excerpt from Levelt (1989), others TBA
9		NO CLASS, THANKSGIVING	
10	Dec 3	Wrap-up, summary, synthesis	
Finals Wk	Fri Dec 11	Final paper **DUE**	